

\$1997 woofer

Bang & Olufsen to launch BeoLab 11 subwoofer starting from a price tag of \$1997

Next stop : 14nm?

TSMC already preparing for 14nm fabrication processes

HD Player Test

a few ebooks on the screen if required. For example, FLAC and FLV files are out of the question. There is no way of running music in the background while browsing through photos or even reading text files!

Xtreamer

The Xtreamer got into the test at the last moment, and we're glad it did. The Xtreamer is in a class of its own. It doesn't come in any fancy clothes as some of the other players in looks. It's a little smaller than the bulkier products and can house a 2.5-inch hard drive within it. The device comes with an optional USB Wi-Fi module for wireless connectivity and it also has an Ethernet port.

The remote control and device allow for good multi-tasking. Music while through the other menus is possible. You can even go to the Setup menu without exiting a movie. You can even enter the time you want to fast forward to. It's almost as good as using a HTPC in several ways.

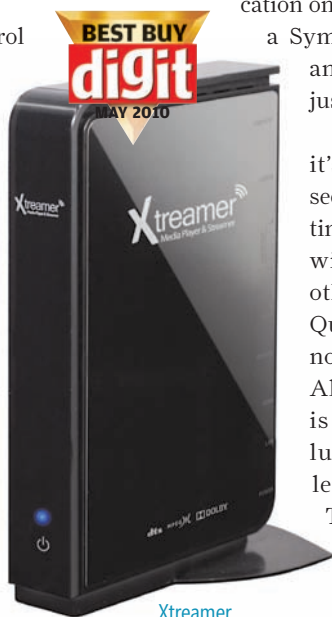
Format support is excellent

and online content in the form of Shoutcast (audio) and Youtube streams is available. The presentation and sorting isn't as professionally done like on the Seagate FreeAgent Theater+, but it isn't shabby. There are plenty of podcasts as well.

The network component isn't there for simply streaming content from Youtube. It can be used as a NAS. It has support for a web server, a media server and a FTP server component. You can even control the device using a web browser. It even lets you upload content and stream content directly off the player on a browser. There's even an iPhone app for it. We tried the web application on Wi-Fi using

a Symbian phone and it worked just fine.

Other than its long (50 second) startup time, it's at par with all the other players. Quality is top notch as well. All in all, this is an absolutely excellent product. The Rs. 8,990 price tag isn't bad either.



Xtreamer

HOW WE TESTED

All the players were tested on a 46-inch full-HD Vu LCD test at 1920x1080. We used HDMI connections on all the players. In the compact products with no HDMI connectors, we used the component connectors. We had our sample videos and movies in different formats. Primarily for quality, we used a 1080p (1920x1080) trailer, a 720p (1280x720) clip and a standard DVD quality 700MB clip. The high-definition clips used were primarily MKV files and the DVD quality test sample was an AVI. We also used a lot

of FLV, Real Media and MOV videos. For the audio test, we primarily used FLAC.

We also recorded the time players take to startup and to load high-definition movies. One of the most annoying moments is fast-forwarding a video clip. Some of the players we received came with many other features which allow users to access content on network shares and even stream content over the internet. Weight was allotted for each one of these features. Build quality of the player, the remote and the range were also kept under consideration.

Final thoughts

Of the two compact players, the WD TV Mini and the Amkette Flash TV, the Flash TV feels limited. It might perform better than the WD TV Mini in image quality but what use is it without good format support. In all honesty, the WD TV Mini is only a little better. The standard WD TV is the better option of the lot.

On the other hand, if you've spent a lot on a full-HD LCD / Plasma TV, you shouldn't be hesitate over a couple of thousand rupees more. For that little more, you get much more media support and features.

The Best Performer award goes to the Iomega ScreenPlay Director for the number fea-



tures, the Bittorrent functionality and also the humongous terabyte drive, which makes a good overall package.

However, the Xtreamer is the one to seriously consider. Except for the Bittorrent feature which would have been nice to have on this player, and a feature that would definitely make it beat the Iomega ScreenPlay Director, it's got pretty much everything you need – performance and quality and if you think about, very affordable if you've just spent on a TV worth Rs. 50,000 or so. For all these reasons, we award it the Best Buy award. Although the Iomega beat it, there's only a gap of 0.84 in between them.

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